



was twisted as a knife that he hurled at his teammates. It was so far from the truth, but a section of the local media went to town with it.

India then went to Canberra, eased past the Prime Minister's XI, landed in Adelaide, and perhaps got blinded by the floodlights, and the pink-ball Test was lost. 1-1 and still a lot to play for. Brisbane's Gabba could have slipped into Australia's grasp, but persistent rains and India's tail ensured that a follow-on was averted and an eventual draw was secured.

Test cricket offers the stalemate as one of the result options. However, in this age of instant gratification, the good old draw is deemed an aberration. Conversely, a defeat while pursuing a difficult triumph is seen as a badge of honour. At the Melbourne Cricket Ground, a terrible last session on the final day meant that India lost the face-off. It was a second innings that needed the durable fortresses that

were in the Rahul Dravid and Cheteshwar Pujara zone. Instead, India had batters returning to the dressing room like misguided projectiles. Batting time is an art that is seriously on the wane.

This litany of woes may indicate that India was constantly playing the second fiddle, but on the turf, even Australia struggled.

Except for Travis Head in the beginning and Steve Smith and Marnus Labuschagne later, the host too suffered from weak batting. Debutant Sam Konstas did tuck into Bumrah a bit, but it was an exception.

Like Bumrah carrying India along, Australia found its biggest hero in Cummins as the captain grabbed wickets and scored handy runs. Mitchell Starc ably assisted him, and Scott Boland was so accurate around the off-stump that it wore down the patience of rival batters. This was pace-hypnosis of the macabre kind, and the Indians walked into it with

Thumping victory: The 3-1 series win against India also means Pat Cummins' side qualifies for the World Test Championship final at Lord's in June, when it will face South Africa.

REUTERS

tentative bats.

In the months ahead, the selectors under Ajit Agarkar have to make some tough calls. A transition is upon the squad; it is a reality that coach Gautam Gambhir and the rest have to address. Sporting cycles are inevitable; there are the highs and the lows.

If the loss at home against New Zealand was seen as this rare banana peel, the crash in Australia is a wake-up call that none should ignore.

To draw joy from ODI and T20 exploits and then use it as a salve for Test wounds will boomerang. New heroes have to emerge, especially ones invested in the longer format.